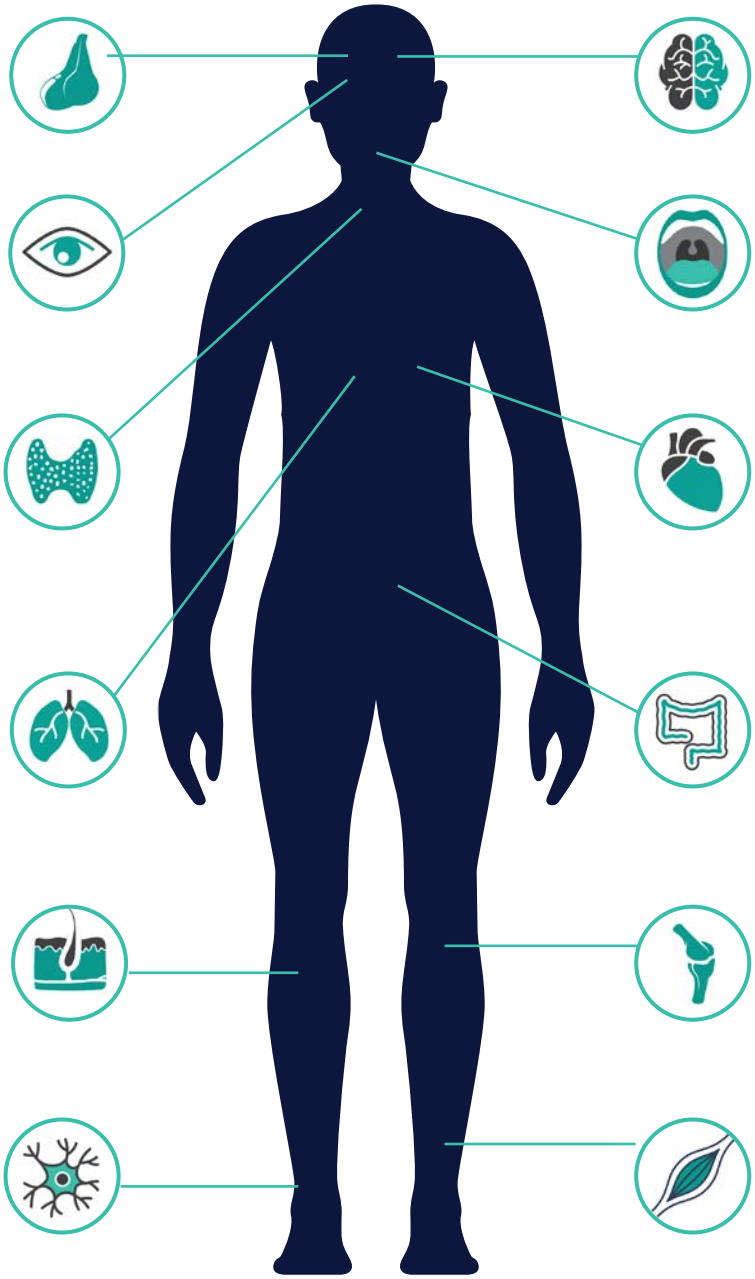
National Comprehensive Cancer Network®

Immunotherapy Side Effects: Immune Checkpoint Inhibitors

Immunotherapy uses the body's immune system to attack cancer cells. Immune checkpoint inhibitors are a type of immunotherapy.

Immune checkpoint inhibitor-related side effects can affect any part of the body. Reporting symptoms when they start can help find the cause or trigger early. It also helps prevent severe side effects.



Pituitary gland
Loss of appetite, nausea, dizziness

Eyes
Blurred or distorted vision, blind spots, eye pain or redness, itchy or bulging eyes

Thyroid
Weight loss or gain, trouble pooping, dry skin, sensitivity to cold

Lungs
Trouble breathing, dry cough, fever, chest pain

Skin
Rash, itching, blisters, itchy bumps and patches, scaly skin

Nerves
Muscle weakness, weakness in face, difficulty breathing

Brain or spinal cord
Headaches, sensitivity to light, confusion, changes in behavior

Mouth
Dry mouth, pain or burning, sores, difficulty eating

Heart
Chest pain, irregular heartbeat, shortness of breath, weakness

Stomach and bowel
Nausea, stomach pain or cramps, fever, watery or loose stools (poops), blood or mucus in stool

Joints
Joint pain, swelling, stiffness

Muscles
Muscle aches, pain, stiffness

For more information, see ***NCCN Guidelines for Patients®: Immunotherapy Side Effects: Immune Checkpoint Inhibitors***, available at NCCN.org/patientguidelines and on the NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer app.

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What is immunotherapy?

- Immunotherapy is designed to work with your immune system to treat certain types of cancer.
- Immunotherapy and chemotherapy are both systemic therapies. These kinds of medicines travel through the bloodstream to treat cancer cells all over the body. But immunotherapy works differently than chemotherapy and can cause different kinds of side effects.

Ask your care team for an immunotherapy wallet card

This card lists your immunotherapy regimen, potential side effects, and contact numbers for your cancer care team.

A printable card is available from the Oncology Nursing Society (ONS) website.

Did you know?

- No matter where your cancer began, side effects related to immunotherapy can affect other parts of your body.
- Feeling tired is common during immunotherapy. So is fatigue. Fatigue is extreme tiredness and lack of energy. But, fatigue can also be related to another condition or side effect.
- Side effects may appear shortly after starting therapy, within the first couple of months, or even after you finish therapy.
- You're more likely to have side effects if you're taking more than a single kind of immunotherapy or immunotherapy combined with other types of cancer medicines.
- Many immunotherapy-related side effects are mild and can be treated. Your care team may prescribe steroids or other medicines to help manage any problems.

This information does not replace the expertise and clinical judgment of the clinician.
If you are experiencing symptoms, contact your cancer care team.

NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Immunotherapy Side Effects series
Available at NCCN.org/patientguidelines

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